

IMPERIAL

Experimental and Computational Investigation of Small-Scale Turbopump Performance with a Novel Barske-Type Impeller



Student: Martin Leung
CID: 02217557
Academic Supervisor: Dr Aaron Knoll
Second Marker: Dr Roderick Lubbock
Department: Department of Aeronautics
Academic year: 2025/2026
Date: 2026/06/01

Department of Aeronautics
South Kensington Campus
Imperial College London
London SW7 2AZ
U.K.

Abstract

Your abstract goes here. Summarise the key motivations, methodology, and findings of your turbopump FYP.

Acknowledgements

Plan of everyone I need to thank, to be written into prose:

Dr. Aaron Knoll, for being my supervisor - Grounding me on my progress and helping me along all the way through admin and safety - Repeatedly told me where I actually was, like telling me to get an extension

Dr. Lubbock - Lending me the torquemeter

Mark Grant - Guiding me on mechanical design, allowing me to test in the hypersonic lab

Hackspace: Fred Holdsworth, David Miller, Mohammed Mehdi Nasr Esfhani - teaching me all about machining over the past 4 years, hundreds of hours of guidance and especially so in this project

Nigel - Guiding me on safety, working through and being patient with this project with a lot of risk and working through the incident report

David Wright - Lending me a lot of fittings from the thermofluids lab of mecheng

Franco - Lending me a lot of the electronics equipment, the box, safety relay, a lot of guidance on safety wiring

Xiao - Giving advice and teaching me about the magtrol system

Liam Donnelly - Rocket turbine FYP who I borrowed a lot of knowledge and equipment from, guiding me on magtrol and the general direction of the project

Rui, Safee - Staying by my side as I test and occasionally even helping me set up and debug. Rui especially helped me solve many many problems

Aleks Kent - Starting the E-pump project in 2023 and inspiring me to get into turbomachinery, and being my best friend

Jordan Farrar, Mark Thornton, Ian Pardew, - For helping me 3d print and laser cut parts, general manufacturing

Roland Hutchins - Allowing me to borrow the garden pump

ICLR - Opportunity and where I learned everything Martin England, Elliot Brookes Gayton, Kiran de Silva - For bringing me into this world of rocketry, electronics and propulsion when I was a first year

Airborne engineering - where I learned a lot a lot of test rig and practical skills

Rudra Nakade - My great friend who I learned so much about doing rocketry with while working with him, and being a poweruser, who eventually convinced me to do a turbopump FYP out of my many rocketry interests

Elsbeth Lau - My great friend who supported me during the harder times of this project

Mom and Dad - For supporting me all I life, sacrificing so much of their life to get me into imperial and supporting my life dream of being a rocket engineer, always being there for me and cheering me on

Mario - Guidance on pump design, and reading this posts on r/rocketry discord let me learn a lot

Oliver Esmond, Tim Barrett - allowing me to borrow ICSS equipment

Chris Noon - allowing me to use their swagelok valvse and test rig equipment from turbomachinery lab

Tian - teaching me about mechanical from 2022 and being my great friend ever since

Contents

Acknowledgements	iii
List of Figures	v
List of Tables	vi
Nomenclature	vii
1 Introduction	1
1.1 Small scale rocket pump challenges	1
1.2 Small scale rocket turbine challenges	1
1.3 Aims and Objectives	1
1.4 Scope and Limitations	2
1.5 Thesis Structure	2
2 Literature and Theory	2
2.1 Pump Literature and Theory	2
2.2 Barske Pump sizing	3
2.3 Barske Pump efficiency	4
2.4 Turbine Literature and Theory	5
2.5 Impulse Turbine	5
2.6 Loss models	5
2.7 Method of Characteristics Blade Profile Design	6
2.7.1 Supersonic Turbine Blade Terminology	6
2.7.2 Transition arcs	6
2.8 Choosing mach numbers	7
2.8.1 Flow separation	7
2.8.2 Starting	8
2.8.3 Mach number selection	8
2.8.4 Finite leading edge	8
2.8.5 Nozzle Design	9
3 Pump Sizing and Mechanical Design	9
4 Turbine Sizing and Mechanical Design	9
4.1 Turbine Design Point	9
5 Experimental Setup	9
6 Results and Discussion	9
6.1 Experimental Campaign	9
6.2 Pump results	9
7 Conclusions	12
References	13
A First Appendix Title	14

List of Figures

List of Tables

Nomenclature

A	Area (m^2)
H	Pump Head (m)
N	Rotational Speed (RPM)
P	Power (W)
Q	Volumetric Flow Rate (m^3/s)
η	Efficiency ($-$)
ρ	Density (kg/m^3)
ω	Angular Velocity (rad/s)

Abbreviations

CFD	Computational Fluid Dynamics
FYP	Final Year Project
NPSH _a	Net Positive Suction Head Available
NPSH _r	Net Positive Suction Head Required

1 Introduction

Rocket engines require high pressures to operate efficiently. Small scale liquid propulsion such as satellite propulsion and amateur liquid rocket propulsion runs almost entirely on pressure fed feed systems due to their simplicity and reliability. Larger orbital rockets use turbopumps because the mass of the required tanks becomes prohibitive. However, as space launch becomes exponentially more accessible, there is a growing interest in small scale rocket propulsion systems. For example, lunar landers, satellite propulsion and amateur liquid rockets are seeing a resurgence in interest. Due to the historical focus on large turbopumps for such applications, turbopumps at the smaller scale are not as well documented and have different design considerations. A turbopump is a pump and the turbine that drives it, and both are punished by the small scale.

1.1 Small scale rocket pump challenges

Pump driven propulsion is the solution orbital liquid rockets use to solve the tank mass problem. By storing propellents at lower pressures and pumping them to the required pressures allows for a large reduction in tank mass. The pump is usually driven by turbines powered by burning a portion of the propellents, or by the heat generated by the cooling of the engine. In recent years, battery and electric pump technology has advanced to such a point that for smaller rockets such as the Electron rocket by Rocket Lab [?], electric pumps are starting to become a more viable alternative to turbine driven pumps. Pumps are generally characterized by their flow rate Q_{opt} , the head H_{opt} and rotor speed n [?]. These three parameters largely decide the pump geometry and type of pump. These three parameters can be related by a quantity known as specific speed, n_q , N_s or ω_s depending on the units and definitions used:

$$n_q = \frac{n\sqrt{Q}}{H^{3/4}} \quad [\text{RPM}, \text{m}^3/\text{s}, \text{m}] \quad (1)$$

Different pump geometries are optimal for different regions of specific speed as can be shown by [?]. Most liquid rocket engines operate between a specific speed n_q of 20 to 40 and utilize the centrifugal radial impeller to maximize efficiency. This works great for large rocket engines, but scaling this down to smaller engines becomes increasingly difficult. All rocket engines require high pressures, but smaller rocket engines require less flow rate. To stay in the specific speed according to eq. (1) that allows for high efficiency in the centrifugal pump requires increasing rotational speed.

To achieve the specific speed of 20 for a smaller rocket engine of around 5 kN requiring 1.0 kg/s of kerosene at 50 bar leads to rotational speeds of around 71 051 rpm. Such high rotational speeds leads to challenging mechanical design conditions. To solve this problem, a single pump can be separated into multiple stages, separating the head rise to increase the specific speed of each stage. This is a common solution to pumping hydrogen. This thesis however addresses the other solution, which is to deal with the lower specific speed.

As shown in [?], at lower specific speeds, the partial admission pump becomes the optimum efficiency pump geometry at specific speeds of 5-10. However, even though these pumps are the most efficient at these low specific speeds, they physically cannot achieve the high efficiencies of a full admission pump. This is the main limitation of trying to operate at low specific speeds.

Due to its lower efficiency and the lack of pump fed liquid rockets for small engines, there is a lack of literature, design knowledge and experimental data surrounding these pumps. This thesis aims to address this gap by reviewing existing literature, designing and manufacturing a partial admission centrifugal pump and comparing its experimental performance specifically in the use case of rocket engines.

1.2 Small scale rocket turbine challenges

On the other end of the turbopump shaft is the turbine which drives the pump. The turbine faces the same problem as the pump. If using the gas generator cycle, the small turbine leads to lower blade speeds U . To extract the maximum work from the gas, gas velocity C_0 must be high, leading to a supersonic blade turbine. The high gas velocity relative to blade speed leads to the turbine running at a lower efficiency than the optimum $U/C_0 \approx 0.5$ [?]. The smaller mass flow also cannot fill the annulus at a sensible blade height, leading to partial admission where only a fraction of the annulus has gas flowing through it at any given time. This makes the stage lossy and awkward to design. In addition to these design limitations, supersonic turbine design is far less studied than subsonic, where methods are scattered across older sources.

This thesis tackles the design of a turbopump in the context of small scale liquid rocket engines which forces both pump and turbine off optimum design conditions, then demonstrates their coupled performance in a full integration test. The thesis is framed around the design of a 20 000 rpm turbopump using water as an inert simulant for the pumped rocket propellents. Then, a supersonic partial admission impulse turbine is designed to drive the pump using compressed air as the working fluid. The two are then coupled together and tested as a single system to evaluate performance.

1.3 Aims and Objectives

The aim of this thesis is to investigate the performance of a small scale rocket low specific speed turbopump with a Barske pump and a supersonic partial admission turbine. To this end, the objectives of this thesis are:

1. Pump characterisation: Determine the head-flow curve, efficiency, and cavitation behaviour of a Barske-type impeller across operating speeds
2. Turbine design and model validation: Design a single-stage partial-admission supersonic impulse turbine with a first-principles computational toolchain, and validate those models against the achievable test data.
3. Turbopump integration: Demonstrate coupled turbopump operation at scaled off-design conditions and perform analytical extrapolation to the full 20 000 rpm gas generator regime.
4. Computational toolchain assessment: Assess the 1D/analytical design toolchain against the experimental data, and establish where analytical prediction is sufficient for this class of machine.

1.4 Scope and Limitations

This thesis covers the theory, design, manufacture and testing of a small scale turbopump system on inert propellents. The pump was tested up to 9000 rpm, significantly lower than the design speed of 20 000 rpm in the first and final iterations of the conducted experiments. This means the data validation can only happen for the off-design point and extrapolation to the design point is required. Cryogenic and hot gas design and testing are strictly outside the scope of this thesis. Operational safety procedures are included in the appendix.

1.5 Thesis Structure

Chapter 2 establishes the pump theoretical background: pump specific speed, Barske impeller characteristics, impulse turbine velocity triangle theory, and the relevant prior literature. Chapter 3 details the pump design and sizing methodology. Chapter 4 covers turbine design, including structural analysis of the rotor at 20 000 rpm. Chapter 5 describes the custom instrumentation and data acquisition system. Chapter 6 documents the test rig and assembly. Chapter 7 presents the experimental results. Chapter 8 discusses the findings in the context of design predictions and prior literature. Chapter 9 draws conclusions and recommends future work.

2 Literature and Theory

2.1 Pump Literature and Theory

Centrifugal pumps have multiple main sources of losses. The one that becomes significant at low specific speeds is the disc friction losses. When a rotor object rotates in a fluid, the shear stresses in the fluid cause a drag torque on the object. In most centrifugal pumps the impeller is disc shaped, and the loss is called disc friction loss. . With low specific speed pumps, disk friction is the main source of loss. At $n_q = 10$, $\psi_{opt=1}$ and $Re = 10^7$, the disc friction is approximately 30% of the useful power of the impeller [?]. Gulich suggests that a high head coefficient reduces the diameter and consequently less disk friction since $P_{RR} \sim D^5$. This is the reason why low specific speed centrifugal pumps physically cannot achieve the same high efficiencies as higher specific speed pumps.

On the other hand, at low specific speeds, impeller losses are low as shown by [?]. As a result, surface finish on the impeller blades are largely unimportant, allowing for simpler manufacturing processes. Conversely, collector losses become dominant. Gulich explains [?] that for $n_q < 12$ even higher efficiencies are expected than with volutes. This simplifies the design and manufacturing of the pump, which is a significant advantage at small scales where tolerances are both harder to achieve but contribute to more significant losses. This is important as the high fluid velocity at the periphery makes the surface finish of the annular casing of primary importance for pump efficiency [?].

The Barske impeller pump design which was developed for the need for manufacturing simplicity and low specific speed applications became one of the highest efficiency designs at this specific speed. The barske impeller operates differently to a normal full emission pump. In a conventional centrifugal pump, impeller blade geometry aims to perfectly guide fluid flow along the blade surfaces in a smooth spiral streamline out of the impeller into the volute [?]. The barske impeller is instead designed to induced almost a pure forced vortex flow where $u = \omega r$ and the fluid is essentially rotating as a solid body with the impeller [?]. This also explains the unimportance of surface finish on the blades, as low relative velocity between the fluid and the impeller means lower friction losses.

Barske comments that the number of impeller blades does not seem to be critical, with 3-6 being operated successfully. However, altering the number of blades can be used to eliminate fluid vibrations [?]. Lock provides corrections for blades from 1 to 16 [?].

The open impeller choice is to further reduce disc friction losses by minimizing surface area. Conventional impellers use shrouds to guide the flow and reduce secondary flows. However, as in a Barske pump the impeller serves only to generate the forced vortex flow, this was deemed unnecessary by at least Barske and Lock. This also removes axial thrust loads on the impeller, helping with sealing and mechanical design of the shaft. Also, simplify manufacturing.

Conventional pump design with current design tools produce nonsensical geometries and results at low specific speeds because of one number that is used in the design process, which is the slip coefficient. The slip coefficient determines the angular deflection of the fluid leaving the impeller from the blade angle at the impeller exit. This number is usually determined

empirically based on regression fits from existing data. However, at $n_q \approx 7$, the equations relating blade exit angle, slip coefficient and head coefficient mathematically does not have a converging root. Physically, there is no blade geometry that can bend the blade enough to keep the flow attached to the blade. This is further motivates the forced vortex Barske architecture, as it does not rely on attached flow, removing slip factor from the design process entirely.

All theories relating to pump and turbine design can be derived from the conservation of angular momentum by Newton's second law of motion. In turbomachinery, this is usually expressed in terms of the Euler turbine equation:

$$P = T_{shaft}\omega = \rho Q (r_2 c_{2u} - r_1 c_{1u}) \omega = \rho Q (u_2 c_{2u} - u_1 c_{1u}) \quad (2)$$

Rewriting this equation in terms of specific work $Y = P/\rho Q$ per unit mass:

$$Y = (r_2 c_{2u} - r_1 c_{1u}) \omega = u_2 c_{2u} - u_1 c_{1u} \quad (3)$$

derive from bernouli, with rotating frame substitution $c^2 = w^2 - u^2 + 2 \times u \times c_u$ and neglecting compressibility losses:

$$p_1 + \frac{\rho}{2} w_1^2 - \frac{\rho}{2} u_1^2 = p_2 + \frac{\rho}{2} w_2^2 - \frac{\rho}{2} u_2^2$$

and as such the theoretical rise in static pressure:

$$\Delta p_{st} = p_2 - p_1 = \frac{\rho}{2} (w_1^2 - w_2^2) + \frac{\rho}{2} (u_2^2 - u_1^2) \quad (4)$$

In Barske, Lobanoff and Lock the relative velocity w is assumed to be negligible, ending up with:

$$\Delta p_{st} = \frac{\rho}{2} (u_2^2 - u_1^2) \quad (5)$$

Then, the kinetic energy increase assuming negligible inlet prerotation is:

$$\Delta p_{st} = \frac{\rho}{2} u_2^2 \quad (6)$$

eq. (6) is the theoretical total pressure a barske impeller generates at the blade tips. In a barske pump, the diffuser is responsible for converting this kinetic energy into static pressure by slowing down the fluid in an expanding diffuser. Barske introduces a loss coefficient for the kinetic energy which can be recovered through the diffuser to be between 0.2 and 0.5. Barske uses the symbol ψ for this coefficient, but as it conflicts with the commonly used symbol for head coefficient, this paper will instead use c_k . Combining the static and kinetic pressure rise, the total increase in pressure is:

$$p_t = p_{sth} + c_k p_{dth} = \frac{1}{2} \rho ((1 + c_k) u_2^2 - u_1^2) \quad (7)$$

This forms a simple basic model for barske pump performance.

2.2 Barske Pump sizing

The barske pump is sized by the methods provided by barske [?] with the assistance of Gulich. First the inlet is sized by choosing a reasonable inlet velocity and calculating the inlet area:

$$d_0 = \sqrt{\frac{4\dot{m}}{\pi \rho c_0}} \quad (8)$$

The impeller blade inlet diameter is enlarged by a small amount as some pre-rotation is desirable for increased head. For example, $d_1 \sim 1.1d_0$.

By substituting $u = \pi n d / 60$ into eq. (7), the required impeller tip diameter can be calculated:

$$d_2 = \sqrt{\frac{1}{1 + c_k} \left(\frac{7200 p_t}{\rho n^2 \pi^2} + d_1^2 \right)} \quad (9)$$

Barske then gives these guidelines for other dimensions of the pump:

$$s_{ax} \leq \min \left(0.75, \frac{d_2}{100} \right) \quad (10)$$

$$b_1 \geq \frac{1}{4} d_1 \quad (11)$$

$$b_2 \geq \max \left(b_1 \frac{d_1}{d_2}, 3s_{ax} \right) \quad (12)$$

$$(13)$$

For the annular casing sizing, Barske doesn't have very specific numbers, so Gulich's guideline where B/H = 1.5 to 2.5 can be followed:

$$B = 2s_a x + b_2 \quad (14)$$

$$H = B/2 \quad (15)$$

To size the diffuser, Barske suggests sizing the diffuser throat to be around 0.8 to 0.9 of u_2 , with the area of the diffuser outlet to be 3-4 times the area of the diffuser throat.

2.3 Barske Pump efficiency

Barske assumes that the disc friction losses can be approximated as a circular disc in a rotating fluid. Converting the equation into metric units gives:

$$P_{RR}[\text{W}] = 1956 \times \rho \nu^{0.2} \left(\frac{n}{1000} \right)^{2.8} (d_2^{4.6} + 4.6d_1^{3.6}b_1) \quad (16)$$

As the hydraulic efficiency is defined as the useful power out of the pump over the total power into the pump, efficiency can be defined as:

$$\eta_h = \frac{\text{Useful power}}{\text{Input power}} = \frac{P}{P_{th} + P_{RR}} = \frac{Qp}{Qp_{th} + P_{RR}} = \frac{p}{p_{th} + P_{RR}/Q} \quad (17)$$

If total shaft efficiency is desired, the mechanical losses can be included:

$$\eta = \frac{p}{p_{th} + \frac{P_F + P_{Mech}}{Q}} \quad (18)$$

Lock provides a refined model which takes into account prerotation, nozzle losses and correction coefficients taking into account theoretical two dimensional flow solutions by A. Busemann [?].

By writing the total theoretical pressure gain in head:

$$H_T = \frac{U_2^2 - U_1^2}{2g} + \frac{U_2^2}{2g} \quad (19)$$

Lock uses busemann's corrections and derives a refined total head, taking into account prerotation:

$$H_{TH} = h_0 \frac{U_2^2}{g} - C_H K_1 \left(1 - \frac{Q}{Q_{op}} \right) \frac{D_1}{D_2} \frac{U_2^2}{g} \quad (20)$$

$$H_{SP} = H_{TH} - \underbrace{\zeta_{LD} \left[1 - \left(\frac{D_3}{D_4} \right)^2 \right]^2 \frac{V_3^2}{2g} - \frac{V_4^2}{2g} + \frac{V_0^2}{2g}}_{\text{diffuser-nozzle loss}} \quad (21)$$

Where $\zeta_{LD} = 0.194$ is the diffuser loss coefficient from Hydraulic Institute's Pipe Friction Manual [?].

By expressing $V^2/2g$ by $(8/g\pi^2)Q^2/D^4$ with $V = 4Q/\pi D^2$, the head can be expressed as a function of flow rate:

$$H_{SP} = h_0 \frac{U_2^2}{g} - C_H K_1 \left(1 - \frac{Q}{Q_{op}} \right) \frac{D_1}{D_2} \frac{U_2^2}{g} - \frac{8Q^2}{g\pi^2} \left(\frac{\zeta_{LD}}{D_3^4} + \frac{1}{D_4^4} - \frac{1}{D_0^4} \right) \quad (22)$$

To find the optimum flow rate used to shape the pump curve, the derivative of the head with respect to flow rate can be taken and set to zero:

$$Q_{op} = \sqrt{\frac{h_0 \frac{U_2^2}{g}}{\frac{24}{g\pi^2} \left(\frac{\zeta_{LD}}{D_3^4} \left(1 - \left(\frac{D_3}{D_4} \right)^2 \right) + \frac{1}{D_4^4} - \frac{1}{D_0^4} \right)}} \quad (23)$$

Lock and Barske suggest that the flow cutoff point is limited by the diffuser throat. To find the static pressure at the diffuser throat, reversing the transfer between dynamic head into static head provided by the previous equations :

$$H_3 = H_{SP} + \frac{8Q^2}{g\pi^2} \left(\frac{\zeta_{LD}}{D_3^4} \left(1 - \left(\frac{D_3}{D_4} \right)^2 \right) + \frac{1}{D_4^4} - \frac{1}{D_3^4} \right) \quad (24)$$

Then solving for the Q at which H_3 is equal to vapor pressure head $H_{vap} = \frac{1}{\rho g} (p_{vap} - p_{inlet})$ gives the flow cutoff point.

2.4 Turbine Literature and Theory

2.5 Impulse Turbine

Turbines work with the same Euler turbine equation. In the supersonic impulse turbine design, the blades are only occupy a small outer portion of the blisk, so the turbine equation can be simplified:

$$\Delta h_{use} = c_{3u}u_3 - c_{4u}u_4 = u(c_{3u} - c_{4u}) \quad (25)$$

From eq. (25), it is understood that a higher flow velocity difference $c_{3u} - c_{4u}$ per unit mass will lead to a higher Δh_0 according to equation eq. (3). This means that high absolute velocities, and for the maximum amount of the flow angled in the circumferential direction is optimal. For this reason, gas generator cycle turbines tend to take advantage of the high pressure ratios and thus the supersonic velocities. Then for the angles, the highest turning angle achievable is optimal. The amount of flow turning is usually limited by the achievable geometry.

Leading to the ideal efficiency of an impulse turbine to be:

$$\eta_{ideal} = 4\phi(\cos \beta_3 - \phi) \quad (26)$$

Where ϕ is the flow coefficient defined as $\phi = c_3/u$ and β_3 is the blade angle at the inlet. The maximum ideal efficiency is achieved at $\phi = \cos \beta_3/2$. By taking the derivative of eq. (26), the ideal U/C_0 is $0.5 \cos \beta_3$. For a small turbine with a diameter of

NASA special publication 8110 shows that for low U/C_0 turbines, impulse turbines are more efficient, even if reaction turbines can have a higher overall efficiency, just not at the low U/C_0 regime. In addition, the same conclusion is drawn by comparing the influence of tip clearance on the two types, where impulse turbines are more robust to tip clearance. This is especially important for small scale turbines where manufacturing tolerances are more difficult to achieve and contribute to more significant losses [?].

Another problem with designing small turbines is with the low blade height required. By calculating the mass flux through the turbine, the blade height can be designed:

$$H_3 = \frac{\dot{m}}{\rho_3 c_{3m} d_{mean}} \quad (27)$$

Where ρ_3 is the density of the turbine gas at the turbine inlet. Using the example turbine above, the required blade height would be . By introducing partial admission, the mass flow through the turbine can be restricted to a smaller arc around the annulus at a slight cost to efficiency. The partial admission ratio ζ can be included into the blade height formula as so:

$$H_3 = \frac{\dot{m}}{\zeta \rho_3 c_{3m} d_{mean}} \quad (28)$$

By reducing the partial admission to , the blade height is increased to . The design of the turbine blade height is very important due to multiple reasons. Firstly, the aspect ratio of the turbine blade determines the magnitude of of the wall boundary layer blockage. For this reason, a aspect ratio between is desired.

Another way to increase the blade height is to decrease the meridonal velocity c_{3m} . This is achieved by increasing the angle that the flow has to turn as $c_{3m} = c_3 \sin(\beta_3)$.

For supersonic flow to develop within a turbine blade passage, a condition called "starting" must be satisfied. On the startup of a supersonic turbine, a normal shock starts at the inlet of the blade passage and as to pass through the whole passage before the flow into and out of the turbine passage can be supersonic.

2.6 Loss models

The main loss model used in the design of the turbine is the one provided by Weiß [?]. There are more general loss models provided by texts such as NASA SP-290, giving loss models for tip-clearance, disk friction, partial admission and incidence losses. However, those models were built on large full-admission, subsonic to transonic turbines. Weiss specifically derived his loss model for the specialized application of a supersonic impulse turbines at small scales (1-200kW). As the regime of the turbine considered in this thesis matches closer to Weiss's model compared to SP-290's model, Weiss's model is used. Weiss describes different models lead to stage efficiency differences of about 10% points. Derived from rocket turbopumps literature and adjusted by in-house measurements, Weiss provides three efficiencies.

$$k_N = \sqrt{1 - (0.0029 M_3^3 - 0.0502 M_3^2 + 0.2241 M_3 - 0.0877)} \quad (29)$$

eq. (29) is the nozzle loss coefficient, relating the actual velocity to the theoretical isentropic velocity by $k_N = c_{No}/c_{No,is}$.

$$\begin{aligned} k_R = & 0.957 - 3.62 \times 10^{-4} \Delta\beta - 2.58 \times 10^{-2} M_{w3} \\ & + 6.39 \times 10^{-6} \Delta\beta^2 + 6.74 \times 10^{-2} M_{w3}^2 \\ & - 7.53 \times 10^{-8} \Delta\beta^3 - 4.30 \times 10^{-2} M_{w3}^3 \\ & - 2.38 \times 10^{-4} \Delta\beta M_{w3} + 1.45 \times 10^{-6} \Delta\beta^2 M_{w3} + 4.25 \times 10^{-5} \Delta\beta M_{w3}^2 \end{aligned} \quad (30)$$

eq. (30) is the loss of velocity along the blade passage through a theoretically impulse blade, relating the actual velocity to the theoretical velocity by $k_R = w_{exit}/w_{inlet}$.

$$P_v = \frac{1.85}{2} (1 - \epsilon) \rho_3 \left(\frac{n}{60} \right)^3 d_m^4 (4.5 b) \quad (31)$$

Finally, eq. (31) captures the losses due to partial admission. Weiss calls this loss ventilation losses, but it can also be called windage losses. Ventilation losses refers to the the non-admitted arc being dragged through stagnant air.

2.7 Method of Characteristics Blade Profile Design

The design so far is based on 1D mean line theory. The design of the actual blade profile which will turn the supersonic flow in the desired direction is often accomplished using an application of the Method of Characteristics to transition a uniform flow field into vortex flow. .

2.7.1 Supersonic Turbine Blade Terminology

Geometry is separated into the turbine blade, and the passage between the flow. Two surfaces are separately designed, and it is common to refer to the top surface as the convex, and the bottom surface as the concave one. This is in relation to the solid blades themselves as opposed to an alternate designation by the top and bottom of the blade passage.

Vortex flow is a special type of supersonic flow in which flow follows a theoretical perfect arc around a central point. This is a very special type of flow field that is achieved by conditions where expansion and compression waves cancel each other to allow shockless rotation of the flow field. The vortex flow is bounded by the two circular arcs of the surfaces of which a desired surface Mach number is achieved. MOC generates the profile for desired mach numbers. Later analysis will need to be required to choose these desired Mach numbers.

A special condition of vortex flow satisfies the equation

$$\frac{V}{r} = \text{constant} \quad (32)$$

Boxer and Goldman nondimensionalizes this equation using the critical velocity $M^* = V/a^*$ where $a^* = \sqrt{\gamma RT^*}$ is the speed of sound at the sonic point. As a^* only depends on stagnation temperature, it is constant along any streamline of fixed stagnation enthalpy. Then, a nondimensional radius r^* is introduced as the sonic velocity streamline in the vortex field, giving the following condition:

$$\frac{M^*}{r^*} = 1 \quad (33)$$

The Prantdl-Meyer angle can be defined from the critical mach number M^* as:

$$\nu(M) = \frac{\pi}{4} \left(\sqrt{\frac{\gamma+1}{\gamma-1}} - 1 \right) + \frac{1}{2} \left(\sqrt{\frac{\gamma+1}{\gamma-1}} \arcsin [(\gamma-1)M^{*2} - \gamma] + \arcsin \left(\frac{\gamma+1}{M^{*2}} - \gamma \right) \right) \quad (34)$$

And the converting between Mach number and Critical Mach number is given by:

$$M^* = \sqrt{\frac{(\gamma+1)M^2/2}{1 + (\gamma-1)M^2/2}} \quad (35)$$

Equations eq. (33) and eq. (35) can be used to derive the nondimensional radius of the upper and lower surfaces of the blade. The end points of this circular arc is exactly the angle by which the inlet flow has to be turned to achieve the surface mach number.

$$\begin{aligned} \alpha_{l-i} &= \beta_1 - (\nu_i - \nu_l) \\ \alpha_{u-i} &= \beta_1 + (\nu_i - \nu_u) \end{aligned} \quad (36)$$

The equations for the outlet are the same as in eq. (36).

2.7.2 Transition arcs

To transition from the uniform inlet flow to the vortex flow, method of characteristics is used to generate the blade profile to achieve this in a shockless manner.

To achieve this, the flow angles from β_i to α_i is discretized into k interval of ϕ_0 to ϕ_k . It is shown by that the flow angle and dimensionless radius R^* is related along its characteristic line with:

$$\phi = \pm \frac{1}{2} f(R^*) + \text{constant} \quad (37)$$

The positive gives the expansion line and the negative gives the compression line. Where $f(R^*)$ is:

$$f(R^*) = \sqrt{\frac{\gamma+1}{\gamma-1}} \arcsin\left(\frac{\gamma-1}{R^{*2}} - \gamma\right) + \arcsin((\gamma+1)R^{*2} - \gamma) \quad (38)$$

$f(R^*)$ for a given flow angle can be calculated with:

$$f(R_k^*) = 2\nu_i - \frac{\pi}{2} \left(\sqrt{\frac{\gamma+1}{\gamma-1}} - 1 \right) - 2k\Delta\nu \quad (39)$$

The result of eq. (39) can be used to numerically solve for R_k^* with eq. (38), and points corresponding to each flow angle along the major expansion characteristic line can be calculated with:

$$\begin{aligned} x_k^* &= -R_k^* \sin(\phi_k) \\ y_k^* &= R_k^* \cos(\phi_k) \end{aligned} \quad (40)$$

The wall segments are generated by starting from the end point of the circular arc, then finding the intersection of the previous wall segment and the mach line from this point. The slope of the mach line with respect to the x^* axis is given by:

$$m_k = \tan\left(\frac{\phi_k + \phi_{k-1}}{2} + \frac{\mu_k + \mu_{k-1}}{2}\right) \quad (41)$$

Where

$$\mu_k = -\arcsin\left(\frac{1}{M_k}\right) = -\arcsin\left(\sqrt{\left(\frac{\gamma+1}{2}\right)R_k^{*2} - \frac{\gamma-1}{2}}\right) \quad (42)$$

By iterating through the flow angles for both the upper and lower surfaces for the inlet and outlet, the full theoretical MOC blade profile can be generated.

2.8 Choosing mach numbers

There are two main factors to consider when choosing the inlet, outlet and surface mach numbers. One is to prevent flow separation, and the other is to ensure that supersonic flow within the blade passage can "start".

2.8.1 Flow separation

Separation occurs in high adverse pressure gradients. In supersonic flow, this happens whenever the flow is decelerating along the surface. There are two main regions on the blade surfaces which separation can occur. At the upper surface, the inlet transition arc accelerates the flow from the inlet velocity until the vortex flow, then decelerates the flow until the outlet. At the lower surface, the inlet transition arc decelerates the flow from the inlet velocity until the vortex flow, then accelerates the flow until the outlet.

Goldman believes that separation on the lower surface is probably not as important as the flow would tend to reattach shortly as the pressure gradient becomes favourable again [?]. Goldman uses the value of the incompressible form factor H_i along the blade surface to predict separation, where Schlichting found that separation usually occurs in the range of H_i from 1.8 to 2.4.

To find H_i along both surfaces, Sasman and Cresci [?] provides a method to calculate the compressible turbulent integral boundary layer with two ODEs.

Once a MOC blade profile is generated and the mach number at every point along the blade is known, the momentum-integral equation and shape-factor equation can be solved as an initial value problem starting from the leading edge governed by the following equations:

$$\frac{df}{d(s/c)} = 1.268 \left[-\frac{f}{M_e} \frac{dM_e}{d(s/c)} (1 + g_w H_i) + A c \right] \quad (43)$$

$$A c = 0.123 e^{-1.561 H_i} M_e \text{Re}_0 \frac{T_e}{T_0} \left(\frac{\bar{\mu}}{\mu_0} \right)^{0.268} \quad (44)$$

$$\frac{dH_i}{d(s/c)} = \underbrace{-\frac{1}{2M_e} \frac{dM_e}{d(s/c)} H_i (H_i + 1)^2 (H_i - 1) \left[1 + (g_w - 1) \frac{H_i^2 + 4H_i - 1}{(H_i + 1)(H_i + 3)} \right]}_{\text{pressure-gradient term: deceleration drives } H_i \text{ up}} + \underbrace{\frac{H_i^2 - 1}{f} A c \left[H_i - \frac{0.011 (H_i + 1)(H_i - 1)^2 T_e}{H_i^2 (C_f/2) \bar{T}} \right]}_{\text{shear term: wall friction relaxes } H_i \text{ back toward equilibrium}} \quad (45)$$

With initial conditions of a flat-plate $\frac{\theta_0}{c} = 0.036 \frac{s_0}{c} \text{Re}_{s_0}^{-1/5}$.

The initial condition for the shape factor is chosen so that it matches closely to the rapidly converging value $H_{i,0} = 1.67$. It is important to note that Goldman provides equations in his NASA TN D-4421 1968 paper that has been shown to not be conservative enough, with tests by Erikson saying that his criteria is a little too optimistic. The method described here is from Goldman's NASA TM X-2095 paper.

2.8.2 Starting

On startup before the turbine passage runs supersonically, a detached bow shock stands ahead of the leading edges. The flow behind this normal shock is subsonic and has lost a significant amount of total pressure. For the turbine to operate nominally with supersonic flow, the passage must be able to "swallow" this shock, allowing the shock to move through the whole passage.

To do so, the post shock flow with a reduced total pressure must have enough of a flow area pass the required mass flow similar to the choked flow condition. A similar condition is the unstart of a supersonic wind tunnel or a supersonic internal intake. However, Boxer noticed in 1952 that due to the large velocity gradient between the channel walls due to turning, the flow cannot be assumed one directional as in the previous examples. Goldman in 1968 provides the condition accounting for the "reduction of mass flow due to curvilinear flow" to calculate the maximum inlet design mach number to ensure starting as:

$$\frac{p_{02}}{p_{01}}(M_i) \geq \frac{Q}{1 - C} \quad (46)$$

Where p_{02}/p_{01} is the total pressure loss across the normal shock, M_i is the inlet design mach number, Q is named the vortex parameter [?] and C is the reduction in mass flow due to two-dimensional flow. Solving this equation for M_i gives the maximum inlet design mach number to ensure starting.

Historically, starting was a major problem for supersonic turbines. Before the theory was established, Colclough had to build a special jig in which every blade could be pivoted to vary the contraction until the blade started.

2.8.3 Mach number selection

The separation criterion limits the acceleration of the flow along the upper surface, and the deceleration of the flow along the lower surface. Then, the starting criterion provides an additional limit on the inlet design mach number based on these surface mach numbers.

However, Goldman notes that for optimum efficiency, the maximum spread of surface number leads to maximum efficiencies. It comes from the obvious fact that a loss of velocity across the impulse blade leads to a loss of kinetic energy, so he posits the efficiency of an impulse blade to be:

$$\eta = \left(\frac{w_{exit}}{w_{exit,ideal}} \right)^2 \quad (47)$$

This is nearly the same as Weiss' eq. (30) loss. Weiss derived his empirical model only of 1D parameters such as inlet mach number and the angled the flow is turned.

What this efficiency tries to capture is the boundary layer friction losses, shocks, and exit wake mixing losses. The effect of spreading the surface mach numbers becomes clear by looking at the vortex equation eq. (33). The larger the mach number spread, the larger the difference in R^* between the upper and lower surface, the larger physical passage width. The wider the channel compared to the blade chord, the lower fraction of the boundary layer thickness to passage width, the lower the wetted surface area per unit flow, and thus the lower the losses.

This is the challenge of supersonic turbine blade design, maximum efficiency is achieved by riding along the edge of separation and starting.

2.8.4 Finite leading edge

In section 2.7, the upper and lower surface are mathematically designed to produce no shocks in transitioning the uniform flow from the nozzle exit into the vortex flow. For no shocks to form, both surfaces must be perfectly parallel to the starting flow. This is problematic because this implies the point where the two surfaces intersect at the leading edge, the angle between the upper and lower surfaces is zero. This creates an impossible to manufacture zero thickness leading edge. Boxer suggests a few methods to solve this issue. He separates design into turbines with a subsonic or supersonic axial velocity component.

For subsonic axial velocity turbines, either lower or upper surface can be designed with an incidence angle to the inlet flow. Angling the upper convex surface and keeping the lower concave surface parallel to the inlet flow, the compressive oblique shock will be generated along the region between the inlet and the nozzle exit, affecting the flow in the next blade passage. Kantrowitz shows that in steady state a compression shock of equal strength will be created to obtain the steady state condition [?]. To solve this, a small angle wedge can be placed shortly after the leading edge to generate a small expansion wave to cancel out the shock.

Another method is angling the lower concave surface so that the shock stays within the blade passage and does not affect the upstream flow. The oblique compression shock can then be designed to intersect the upper surface at an angle to fully cancel out the shock.

For supersonic axial velocity turbines, a wedge can be designed on the convex surface with a low enough angle from the design inlet flow so that the shock stays within the blade passage and can be cancelled out by a kink on the concave surface.

2.8.5 Nozzle Design

Historically, the optimal nozzle design for an ideal inviscid gas was designed with the Method of Characteristics as well. Rao provides a method to achieve this [?]. NASA special publication 8120 explains that a single canted parabola closely approximates the ideal nozzle contour and should be used for high performance nozzles. In this paper, the nozzle was a simple conical nozzle with a 7 degree half angle. It can be seen from [that the performance of a conical nozzle for low area ratios lead to a efficiency loss below 2%.](#)

3 Pump Sizing and Mechanical Design

4 Turbine Sizing and Mechanical Design

4.1 Turbine Design Point

Turbine sizing has to satisfy many requirements simultaneously, many design variables. After the pump was sized for 20 000 rpm at a power of 2.6 kW, there are many remaining free variables.

The main parameters being turbine diameter D_{mean} , mass flow through the turbine $\dot{m}$, blade inlet angle β_3 .

5 Experimental Setup

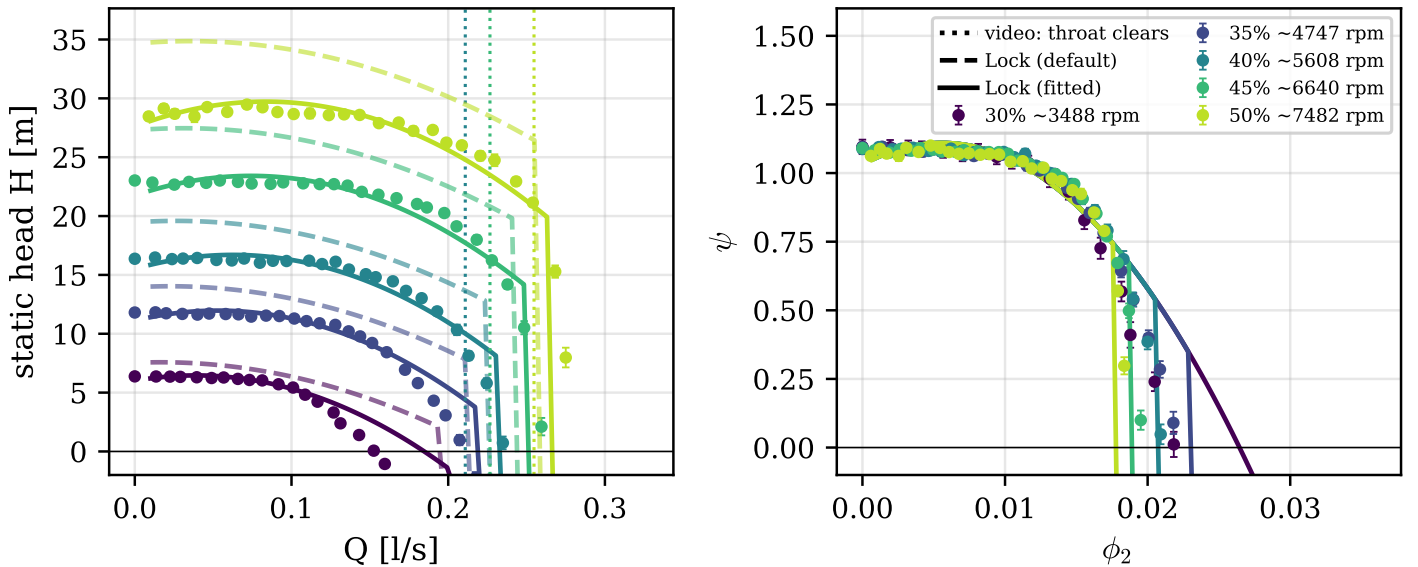
6 Results and Discussion

6.1 Experimental Campaign

The experimental campaign was conducted in three phases: commissioning, electric motor driven pump testing, then integrated turbine and pump testing. The standalone turbine testing was not conducted due to time constraints.

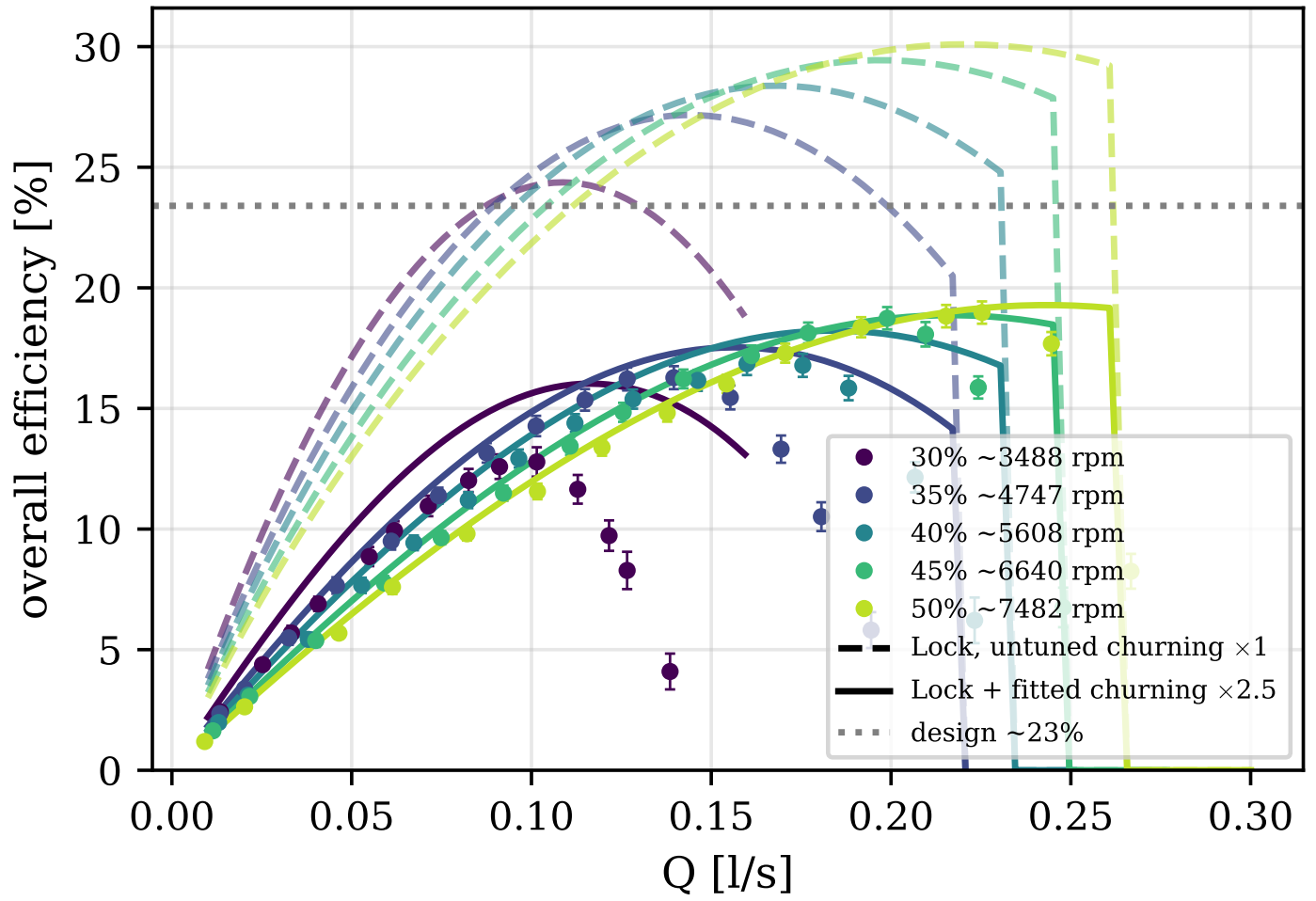
6.2 Pump results

There are two main curves that are used to evaluate pump performance: the head-flow curve and the efficiency curve. The head-flow curve shows the achievable head at different flow rates and will be discussed first.



section 6.2 Shows the actual achieved head rise across flow rates at the different RPMs that were tested. Overlaid are solid and dashed lines. Both are theoretical head-flow curves generated from eq. (22). The dashed line is with exactly the parameters from Lock's paper, and the solid line is with the pre-rotation K increased from 0.17 to 0.53. The dashed vertical line shows the point at a synchronized video camera detected cavitation within the diffuser through the transparent diffuser wall. It can be seen that the original parameters overpredict the head rise, and there are many mechanisms that could be causing this.

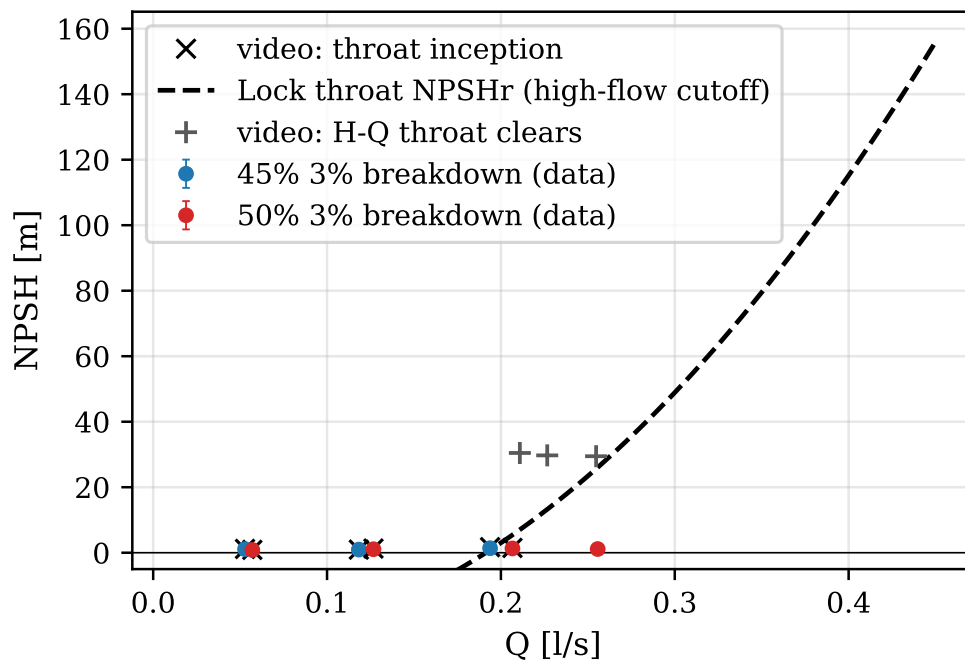
The efficiency curve generated by measuring shaft power, subtracting mechanical losses can be shown in the following graph:



The right graph shows the predicted efficiency curve from pure theory, and the right graph shows the curve but with adjusted disc friction. To explain the disc friction adjustment, the pump data at zero flow where all the shaft power was only going into hydraulic losses:

churning_power.png

section 6.2 shows that the measured disc friction losses are about 2.5 times higher than barske's formula for disc friction. Adjusting the disc friction by this factor leads to a much better fit of the efficiency curve, as can be seen in section 6.2. Specifically for rocket engine applications, the cavitation behaviour is of high importance. The following graph shows the cavitation curve generated by plotting the head at which cavitation was observed at different flow rates:



section 6.2 shows the NPSH required to avoid cavitation at different flow rates. The dashed line is the theoretical curve generated by solving eq. (24) for the flow rate at which the head at the diffuser throat is equal to the vapor pressure head. Two interesting observations here.

futu
wor
the
tion
tha
des
wh
onl
see
slov
clos
the
let
inst
of v
did
is s
clos
let
bas
just
test
non
my
was
to c
wh
fou
unl
nee
ana
the
cur
Yes
do

References

A First Appendix Title

Appendix content goes here (e.g., calibration curves, large tables, or code).